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BACK TO THE BASICS
Sunil Bansal, the BJP's Bengal in-charge, at a door-to-door membership drive in Chowringhee, Kolkata

▶ WEST BENGAL

BJP Woos Loyalists Over Turncoats

No more defectors in Bengal—at least that seems to be the message as Sunil Bansal ushers in a strategic shift for saffron

growth was a necessity when starting from zilch, but it soon created a situation where instability was a structural feature, not a bug.

How to move through such a fog? Bansal has a compass. Identify two or three leaders in each assembly segment, he told district-level leaders gathered at the BJP's Salt Lake office recently. Criterion: they have to have stayed with the BJP through its highs and lows. Such loyalists, by nature unlikely to defect, must be brought to the forefront, he said. The hint: this set would form the core pool of candidates for 2026. Says a senior partyman present at the meeting, "He did not say it explicitly, but the message was clear—the days of importing candidates may be over. Visibility won't matter." That is, only good apples.

Takeaways

- **Bansal's organisational clean-up prioritises party over personal ambition**
- **District units will identify loyal grassroots faces: a core pool of candidates for 2026**

In the 2021 poll, the party banked on high-profile turncoats, particularly from the Trinamool Congress (TMC). The dividends were immediate: from three seats in 2016, the BJP catapulted to principal Opposition status with 77 seats. But it didn't take for that hastily erected minar to start shaking. Many victors defected right back to the TMC, reducing the BJP's effective strength in the assembly to the present 65.

FOREIGN INVASION

Old-timers blame Vijayvargiya's obsession with rapid growth for eroding organisational coherence and voter trust. Some cite the many defeated candidates and say his approach actually thwarted the potential for higher numbers. Even his main confidant, Mukul Roy, a TMC turncoat, famously returned to his old party within days of his 2021 defeat.

At any rate, Vijayvargiya became widely unpopular among the rank and file—he was alleged to have worked in collusion with the TMC, insulted and sidelined long-standing BJP workers, even apparently defied the RSS. Posters demanding his ouster surfaced across Kolkata, forcing him out of the frame for a while. He reappeared two months after the results—in an online meeting—only to face angry party workers.

Bansal marks a change even there. "There's something about him. He looks like a man with a plan. Everyone listens to what he says," a source lets on. He's saying plenty of things, too, drawing lines in the sand. District units have been refurbished with clear, accountable, representative tiers. One new rule is a clear separation of party work and elections. He has barred district heads from contesting in 2026. Each district gets an oversight committee—its members, too, will sit out.

A booth-level outreach starts mid-May. Rallies will follow. A crescendo will be built up with mathematical precision. Bansal is keeping the books. ■